Terms of Reference
Strategic Management Committee
Decade of Action for Cryospheric Sciences (2025–2034)

Background

On August 13, 2024, the United Nations General Assembly adopted Resolution 78/321, proclaiming 2025 to 2034 as the Decade of Action for Cryospheric Sciences. The resolution aims to accelerate efforts to address the urgent challenges posed by the melting cryosphere through enhanced scientific research, monitoring, and international cooperation. The resolution highlights the need to understand the cryosphere's role in the Earth's climate system, freshwater resources, ecosystems, and human social, political, and economic activities. It also calls for raising awareness of cryospheric loss and encourages the sharing of best practices to build resilience against related risks. Member States, UN bodies, and stakeholders are invited to support these activities. UNESCO is tasked to lead the implementation of the Decade, with other UN organizations and partners, using voluntary contributions to develop programmes.

During the first year of the Decade, 2025, an Ad Hoc Committee was established by UNESCO to develop the structures necessary to implement the Decade. These are summarised in a **Synthesis Document**, which outlines the vision for the Decade. As a result of this process, the committee identified five Overarching Challenges (OC) for the Decade:

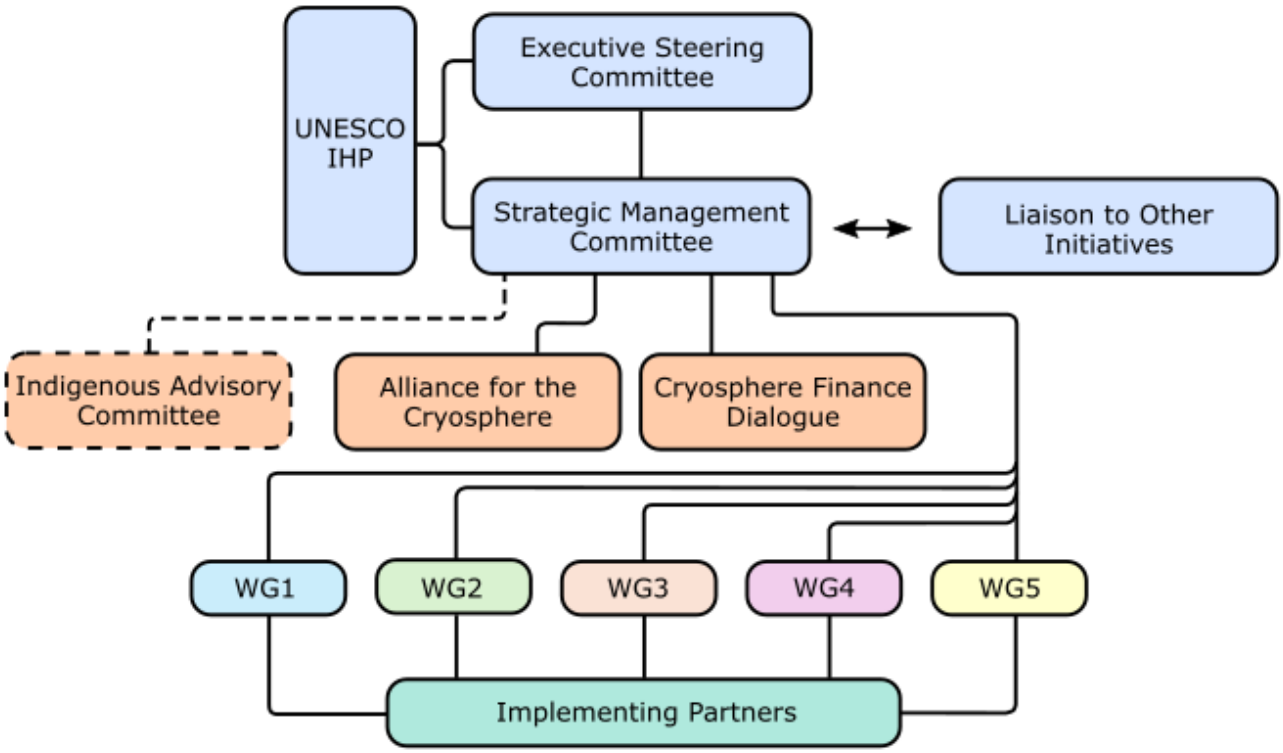
- OC1. Global Cryosphere Monitoring
- OC2. Actionable Cryosphere Projections
- OC3. Cryospheric Risk Management Solutions
- OC4. Adaptation to Cryosphere Loss
- OC5. Amplify the Impact of Cryospheric Science

Within the Decade, Working Groups aligned with each OC serve as the *main workstream of delivery*. The Synthesis Document calls for a **Strategic Management Committee (SMC)** which acts as the core decision-making and coordination body of the Decade to manage these Working Groups. The SMC is chaired by a Chair appointed by, and serving at the discretion of, the Executive Steering Committee. The SMC brings together the Leads of the five Working Groups, the Lead of the Cryosphere Finance Dialogue, the Coordinator of the Alliance for the Cryosphere, representatives of the Indigenous Advisory Committee, and additional thematic representatives covering science, policy, education and partnerships, ensuring geographical, gender and inter-generational balance.

The SMC will hold Working Groups accountable for the main goals and deliverables of the Decade, coordinate cross-cutting activities (including finance, education, observations and modelling, communication and outreach, partnerships), oversee activities in cryospheric regions, and report to the Executive Steering Committee and UNESCO. The Alliance for the Cryosphere and Cryosphere Finance Dialogue groups will report to the SMC. Its chair will serve as ex officio on the Executive Steering Committee. The SMC also acts as a liaison to other related initiatives (e.g. the International Polar Year, other UNESCO scientific decades), and to the broader international scientific community, Indigenous and local knowledge holders, civil society and the general public.

The following diagram shows the structure of the Decade and the connexions to the SMC.

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Objectives

Based on the Synthesis Document and additional scientific and relevant information (such as Ocean Decade, IYGP, Polar Year and other relevant international years and decade), the SMC will be tasked to coordinate and provide strategic management decisions for the Decade in order to meet its Overarching Challenges successfully. The SMC will oversee and coordinate the activities of the five Working Groups and ensure they are meeting the triennial goals set to address the Overarching Challenges. It will receive input from and coordinate the Indigenous Advisory Committee, and the Alliance for the Cryosphere and the Cryosphere Finance Dialogue groups. The SMC will also ensure integration with the Decade's overarching vision and alignment with UNESCO's coordination role. The SMC will work with UNESCO to hold triennial Decade Plenary Meetings to assess progress and plan for the next triennium. The SMC shall uphold the scientific integrity of the Decade, ensuring full alignment with the Synthesis Document and shall structure its work around the three triennia (2025–2028, 2028–2031, 2031–2034), each culminating in a Triennial Cryosphere Summit.

In the transition period, an Ad Hoc SMC will work to establish Working Groups and mechanisms to launch the Decade and will be transformed later to the full SMC once approved by the Executive Steering Committee.

Mandate and deliverables

The *Ad Hoc* SMC will develop:

- A proposed structure for the Working Groups, including scope, membership profiles, thematic or challenge-based configuration, and coordination mechanisms;
- Terms of Reference for the Working Groups;
- A roadmap for establishing and activating the Working Groups;
- A Synthesis Report, bringing together inputs received from key stakeholders (e.g. Member States, scientific institutions, Indigenous groups, youth, civil society, and UN partners).
- A plan for the Technical Launch of the Decade on March 19-20 2026 at UNESCO HQ.
- A roadmap for implementation of the Decade structure and processes.

Once the Ad Hoc phase is concluded and the Decade is fully operational, the SMC shall additionally:

- validate and periodically revise the Terms of Reference of the Working Groups, the Cryosphere Finance Dialogue and the Alliance for the Cryosphere;
- approve the annual workplans of the Working Groups, the Finance Dialogue and the Alliance, and monitor progress against the Main Goals of the Overarching Challenges and Triennial milestones;
- decide on the location, programme and outcomes of the Triennial Cryosphere Summits;
- endorse flagship Decade publications, and other major deliverables of the Working Groups before their public release;
- approve and oversee the implementation of the Decade's communication and outreach strategy, including the procedure for the use of the official Decade logo;
- oversee the establishment, operationalisation and ongoing work of the Indigenous Advisory Committee, in co-development with Indigenous knowledge holders;
- provide strategic guidance on partnerships, fundraising and the mobilisation of voluntary contributions, in coordination with the Cryosphere Finance Dialogue and the UNESCO IHP Secretariat;
- report annually to the Executive Steering Committee and to UNESCO governing bodies on the progress of the Decade.

Structure

The SMC will be composed of members reflecting the leadership of the Decade's delivery structures and additional thematic and stakeholder representation, with size adjusted as the Decade evolves, nominated by UNESCO in consultation with key stakeholders and approved by the Executive Steering Committee, ensuring balance in terms of:

- Geographic representation
- Thematic expertise
- Stakeholder representation (Scientific and professional organization, governments, academia, Indigenous Peoples, youth, NGOs, financing and philanthropy)
- Gender and inter-generational diversity

In particular, the SMC shall include:

- the Leads of the five thematic Working Groups (OC1-OC5);
- the Lead of the Cryosphere Finance Dialogue;
- the Coordinator of the Alliance for the Cryosphere;
- representatives of the Indigenous Advisory Committee;
- individuals with proven experience in intergovernmental processes, coordination of scientific or policy initiatives, and inclusive engagement;
- additional thematic representatives covering science, policy, education, finance and partnerships, including at least one early-career representative.

Members serve initial three-year terms, aligned with the three triennia of the Decade and renewable once. A transitional overlap of up to six months between outgoing and incoming officers shall be maintained to preserve continuity. Associate Leads of the Working Groups may attend SMC meetings as alternates of their respective Leads, when required.

Participation is voluntary and non-remunerated.

Modus Operandi

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- The Committee meets monthly during the Ad Hoc transition phase and at least quarterly thereafter, virtually or in person, with extraordinary sessions convened by the Chair as required.
- UNESCO IHP will serve as the Secretariat and facilitate communication, document drafting, and logistical support. The composition of the SMC Members are nominated by the UNESCO IHP Secretariat and confirmed by the Executive Steering Committee.
- The Chair is appointed by the Executive Steering Committee on recommendation of the UNESCO IHP Secretariat. The SMC may elect one or two Vice-Chairs from among its members to support the Chair.
- Draft agendas and documents shall be circulated at least one week in advance of each meeting. Decisions of the SMC are taken by consensus. Where consensus cannot be reached on a substantive matter, the Chair shall refer the matter to the Executive Steering Committee for guidance.
- Committee members will be expected to consult their respective networks and constituencies.
- The SMC shall uphold the scientific and ethical integrity of the Decade, in line with the Synthesis Document.
- The SMC shall coordinate cross-cutting work among the Working Groups, the Cryosphere Finance Dialogue and the Alliance for the Cryosphere, including at least one joint meeting per year of these bodies.
- The SMC shall report annually to the Executive Steering Committee on the progress of the Decade, and at each Triennial Cryosphere Summit on the achievement of Main Goals.

Website

The Strategic Management Committee's proceedings, consultation summaries, and interim deliverables will be published on the Decade's official website: www.un-cryosphere.org/

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